# AN IMPOTENT HQ

## GENERAL EXTRAORDINAIRE: THE RISE OF BIJJI KAUL

In 1957, when it was becoming obvious to Nehru that his Panchsheel policy with China was going nowhere, he had turned to Krishna Menon who was described by *Time* magazine as being the second most powerful man in India after the prime minister. As the defence minister of India, his appointment coincided with the elevation of General Thimayya to the top job in the Indian Army. In his younger days, Menon had been one of the founder-editors of the Pelican imprint of Penguin Books in London before he went on to play an active role in the Indian freedom movement, taking a belligerent stance against Western imperialism. This endeared him to the Soviets and vilified him in the West. After Independence, Menon emerged as the spokesperson for India's foreign policy and the architect of the non-aligned policy. His marathon speech before the United Nations Security Council where he outlined India's stand on Kashmir made him a hero in India. During most of the initial talks between Nehru and Chou (until 1956), it was Krishna Menon who was invariably present, supervising the recording of each and every word spoken by the two leaders.

Temperamentally Krishna Menon was a loner, and having had no ministerial or administrative experience, he found it necessary to disguise this deficiency by affecting a perpetual sneer at officialdom. He also sought to dominate the military bureaucracy by trying to make a dent in the solidarity of its senior ranks. In this he succeeded to the extent that Bijji Kaul—basically loyal by nature but emotional, insecure and ambitious—fell for his blandishments and for a time an unwonted relationship was established between the minister and the general officer.

At the same time, Krishna Menon would have probably never have ventured into playing these devious mind games if the signal had not come from Nehru himself. It was Nehru who had built a strong rapport with Kaul; he had allowed this friendship to often overshadow the official relationship,